COMPARISON NOTE

# Tessera and the online word games

*How a small desktop game sits beside Woogles, ISC, Scrabble GO and UniWords*

**Short version:** Tessera is not really competing with Woogles, ISC, Scrabble GO or UniWords. They are online services with player pools; Tessera is a Windows desktop game with strong bots and analysis. Tessera wins on offline play, tournament word lists, bot strength and after-game analysis. It loses on everything social: no accounts, no matchmaking, no chat, no ratings ladder, no phone or browser version.

| | Price | Where | Play style | Standout |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Tessera** | Free (this project) | Windows desktop | Offline bots, 2-4 players hosted by a friend on the LAN, or a tournament run by one of them | Quackle bots, CSW24/SOWPODS, move-by-move analysis, house rules, spectators, three tournament formats |
| **Woogles** | Free, donation-funded non-profit | Browser | Live rated games, tournaments, puzzles | Serious tournament play, open source, both word lists, strong bots, chat |
| **ISC** | Free; paid membership for extras | Browser (was Wordbiz) | Live games, seeks, kibitzing | The old home of tournament Scrabble; many languages, ~35 bots, deep ratings |
| **Scrabble GO** | Free with ads; gems; Club about $5-8/month | iOS/Android | Async games, leagues, boosters | Official licence, 45M installs, very polished, very monetised |
| **UniWords** | Free, no ads, no purchases | iOS/Android/web | Async, tournaments, ELO | Clean indie alternative; English + Danish, Oxford dictionary, word explanations |

## Where Tessera wins

- **No internet needed.** Bots, rules and analysis all run on the machine.
- **Bots that actually play.** Quackle at Club/Expert/Master is stronger than the built-in opponents in Scrabble GO or UniWords.
- **Real tournament lexicons.** CSW24 and SOWPODS, hash-verified, not an app's own house dictionary.
- **Analysis.** Best play per turn, equity lost, verdicts and a summary. The free apps either do not offer this or charge for it.
- **Self-hosted games.** Two to four people plus spectators, hosted by one player, with house rules the host controls.
- **Self-hosted tournaments.** Swiss, round robin or knockout, filled with friends or bots, one live table at a time and a ladder between matches. Woogles has real tournaments with many entrants; the other apps do not let a player run one.

## Where Tessera loses

- No strangers to play: no accounts, no lobby, no matchmaking, no ratings.
- No chat. (A dropped player does get a minute to reconnect, three times per game, before forfeiting.)
- Windows only, needs Python and an install; no phone or browser build.
- LAN-style networking only; exposing it to the open internet needs a token check first.

## The honest positioning

Tessera is closer to a training and club tool than a Scrabble GO rival. Against Woogles it is the offline equivalent: same serious approach, no community. Against Scrabble GO and UniWords it is the opposite trade: better play and analysis, far less convenience.

If Tessera is to compete online, the missing pieces in rough order are accounts, a lobby with matchmaking, chat, a rating system, and then a web or mobile client. The game itself is already ahead of most of them, and it now survives the dropped connections that plague casual online games.

## Sources


- Woogles: https://woogles.io/ and https://woogles.io/terms
- Internet Scrabble Club: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Internet_Scrabble_Club
- Scrabble GO: Google Play listing and https://www.scopely.com/en/games/scrabble-go
- UniWords: https://uniwords.io/faq/ and https://uniwords.io/